

Editorial

Blame It On Tech

TS ELIOT had foresight. “April is the cruellest month,” he wrote in his classic poem *The Wasteland*. In the world of technology, nothing could have been crueler than last month when a bunch of Pune-based BPO employees defrauded Citibank’s clients of more than Rs 1.5 crore, and a boy from Nashik (Maharashtra) repeatedly molested a girl from Mumbai when she visited him after he confessed his love for her online.

No wonder, then, that the daggers are drawn, and technology is back to being the villain.

This column has always argued that it is not technology that is the villain, but lack of effective regulation. Branding technology as the perpetrator of the crime (or even an accomplice) is not only being short-sighted but also displays a complete lack of knowledge of technology as well as history. It is a classic case of missing the woods for the trees.

Bigger frauds have taken place even when technology was not predominant (remember Harshad Mehta and Ketan Parekh?); women have been sexually attacked since time immemorial by men with twisted brains (even our epics carry stories of exploitation); and teenagers and adults have always exchanged pornographic material among each other.

The question then begs itself: Why does technology get the blame?

The answer is that is most people, especially those that make the laws (or are supposed to), do not understand technology. Worse, they are scared of it. It is similar to when people get scared of learning mathematics, they pin the blame on it for earning fewer marks. So then, is mathematics to blame, or is the person unwilling to understand the nuances of the subject the culprit?

To take the argument further, should we blame credit cards for financial fraud, or cars for road accidents, or nuclear weapons for the WWII twin Japanese disasters?

Admittedly, technology provides avenues for a lot of things. It also provides avenues for crime. Which is why, the anti-India anti-outsourcing propaganda in the US is on thin ground. Mature commentators in the US, in fact, are praising the Indian police’s quick action to nab the Pune culprits. On the popular Web site motleyfool.com, columnist Rich Smith says that data may



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be more secure in India primarily because we have checks and balances in place, like the cybercrime units of the police force. They may not be the world’s greatest online detectives, but their fast action in the Pune case may deter future online criminals.

While the Pune action is heartening, it also exemplifies how, until the regulations are enforced, crime will happen. Until then, the authorities will keep blaming technology. Maybe we will have to just live with it!

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